

‘Hey mum, I dropped my phone down the toilet’: Investigating Hi Mum and Dad SMS Scams in the United Kingdom

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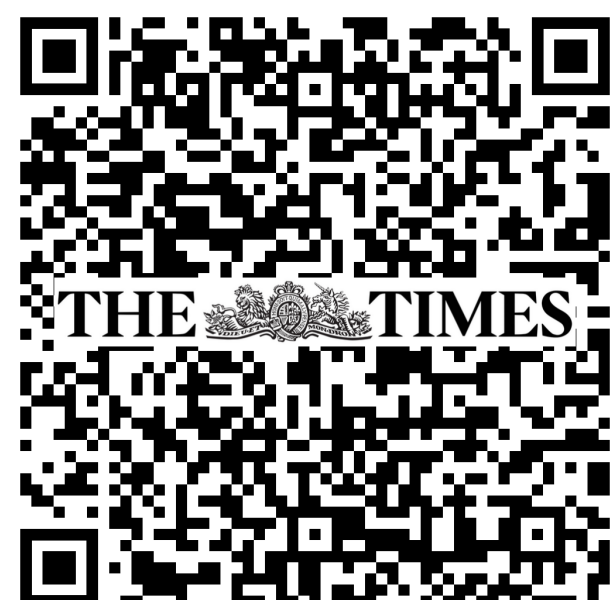
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‘Hi Mum and Dad’ ... inside the emotive text scam

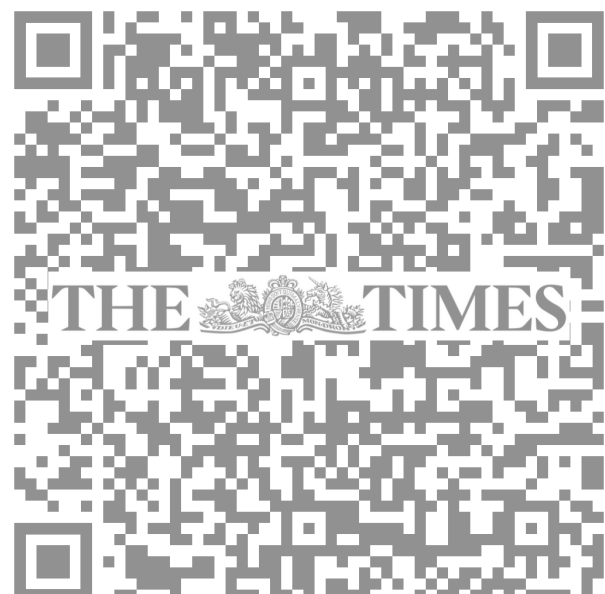
Fraudsters are posing as vulnerable children to trick parents out of thousands of pounds — but the police and phone companies are playing catch-up

Full Article:

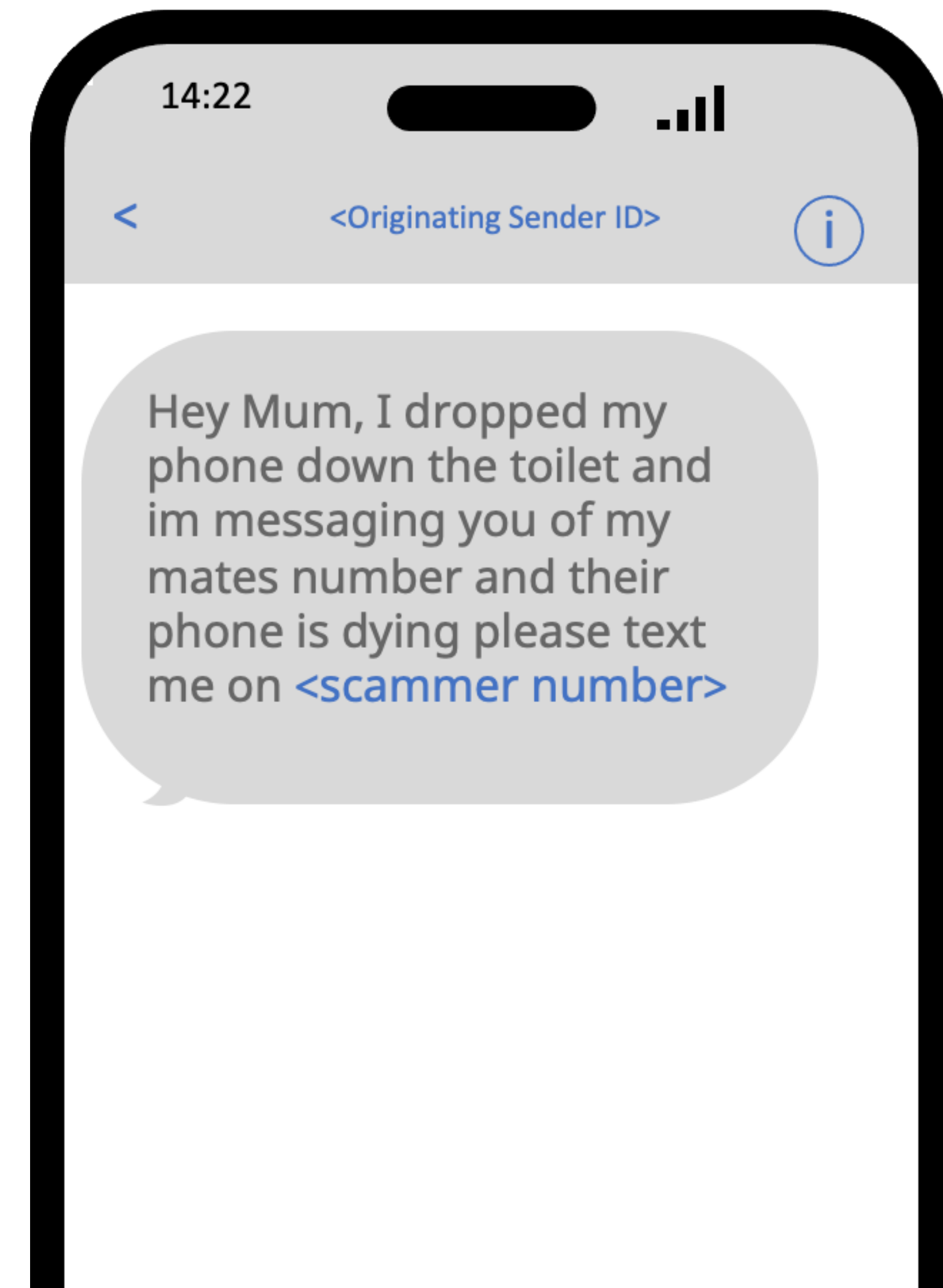


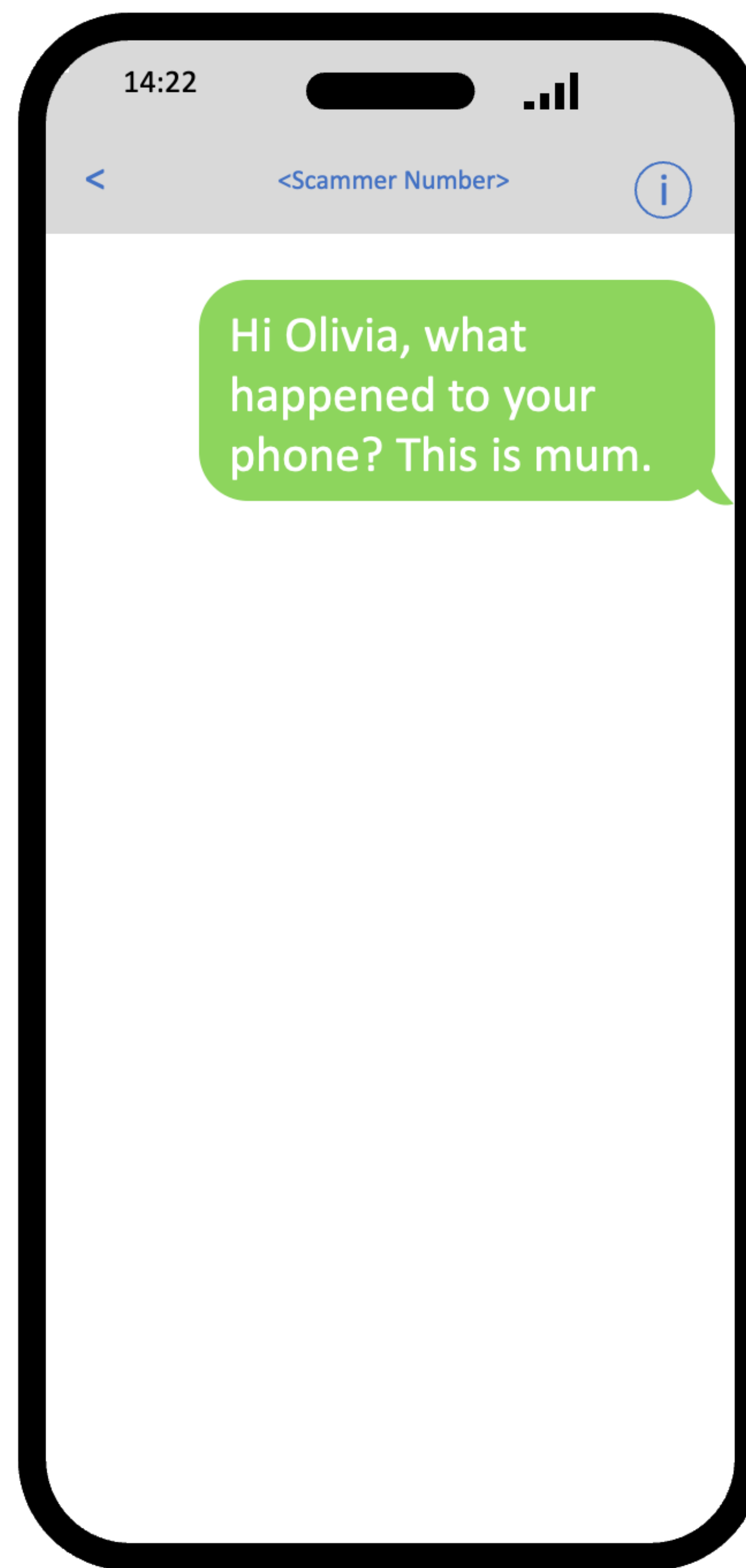
‘Hi Mum and Dad’ ... inside the emotive text scam

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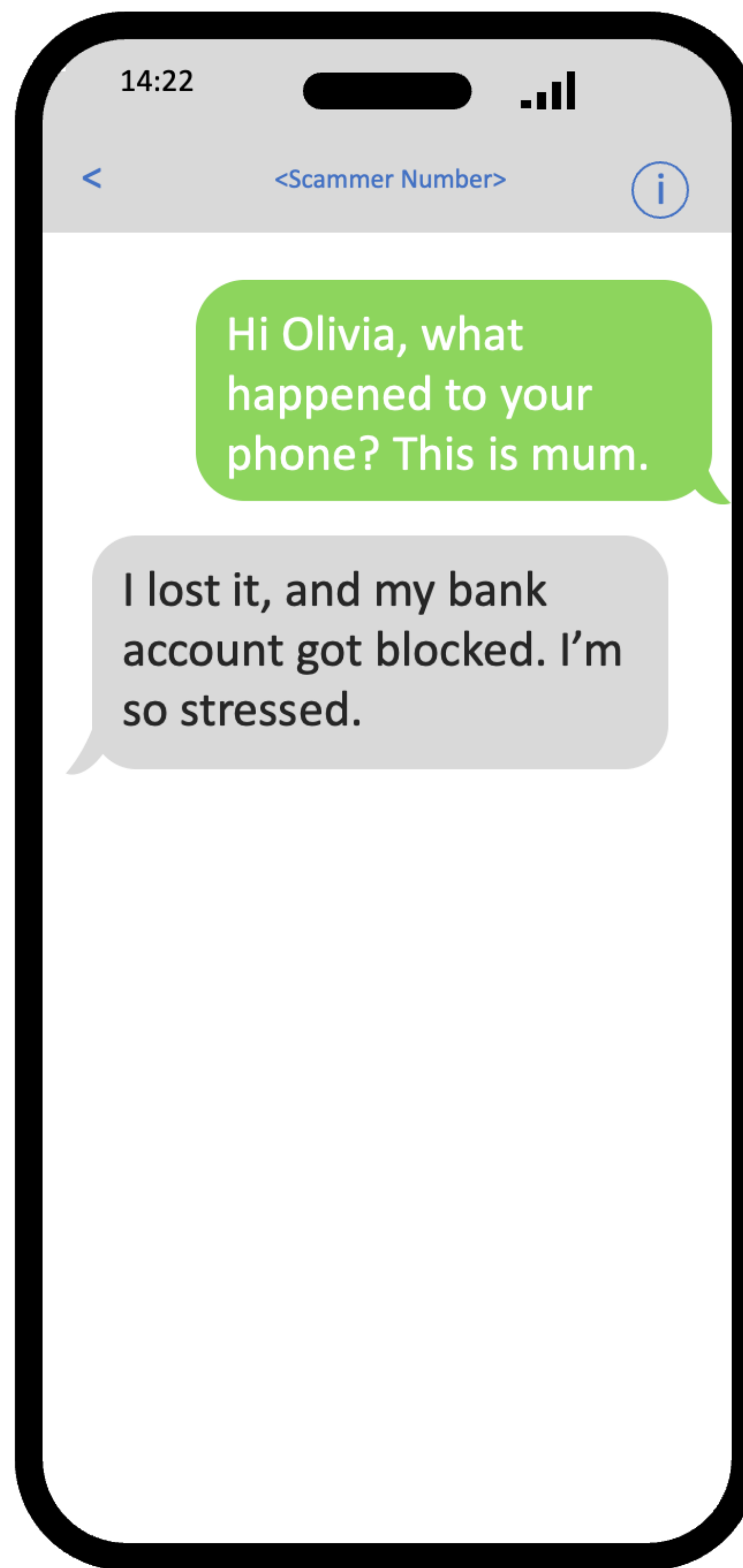
Initial scam text

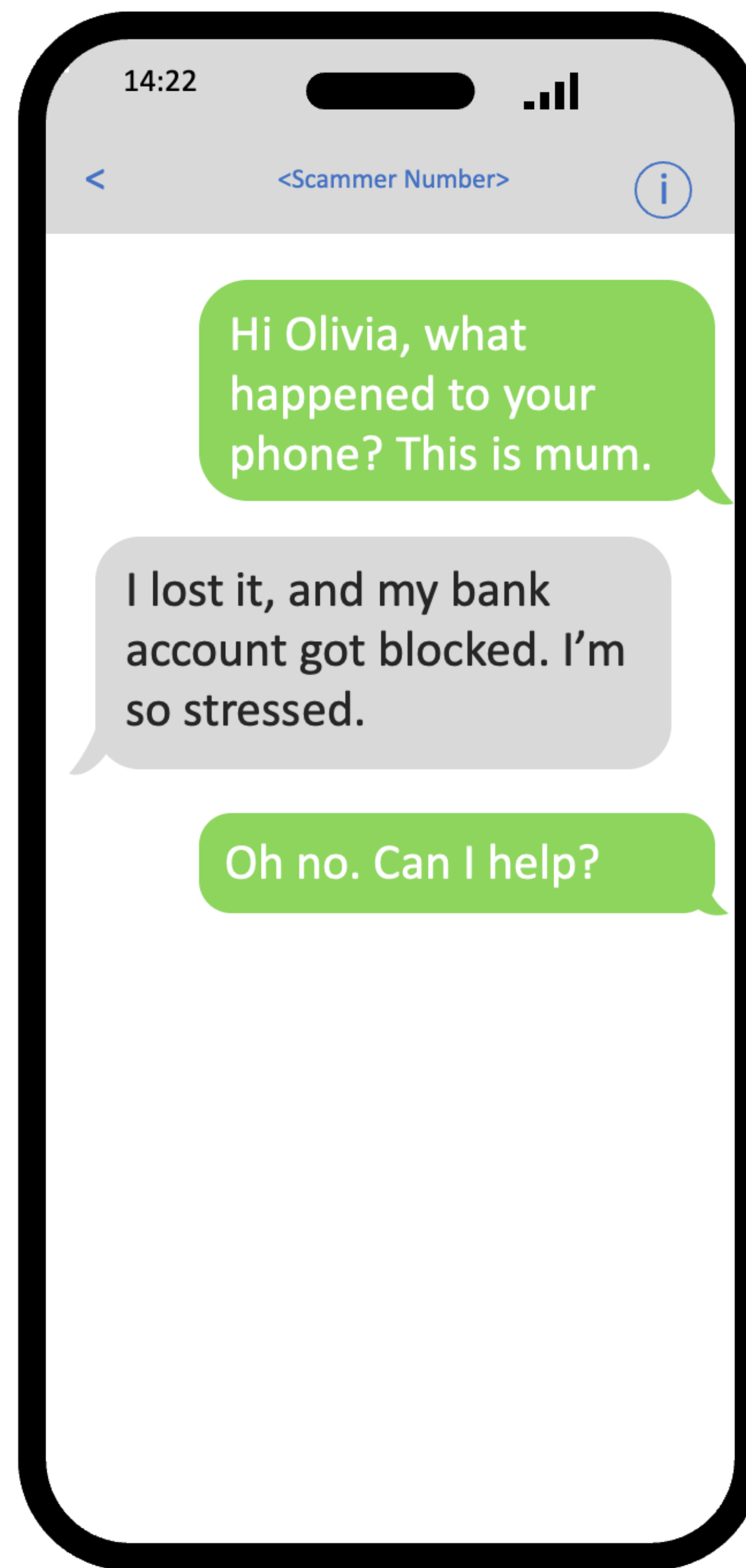




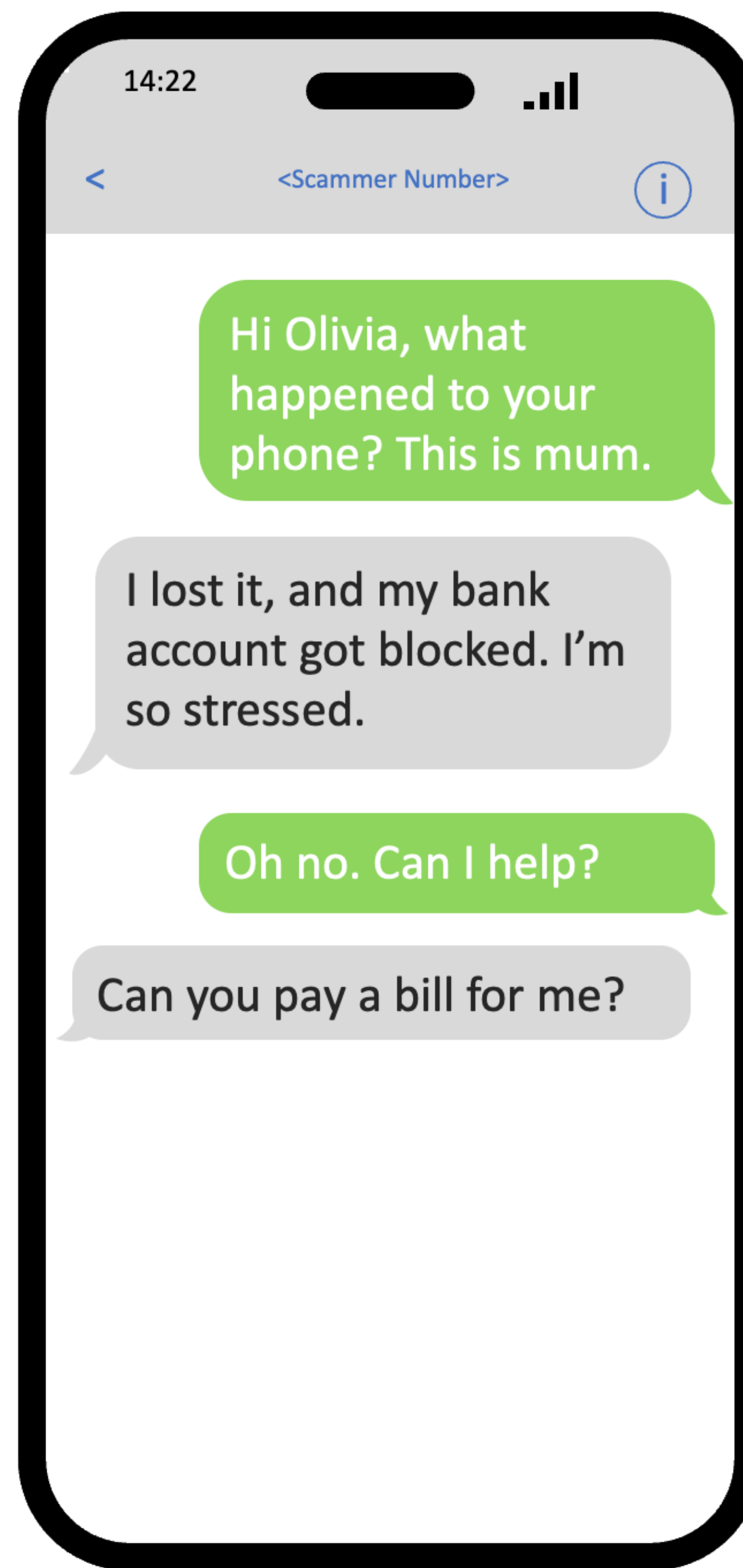
We initiate conversation with
scammer number

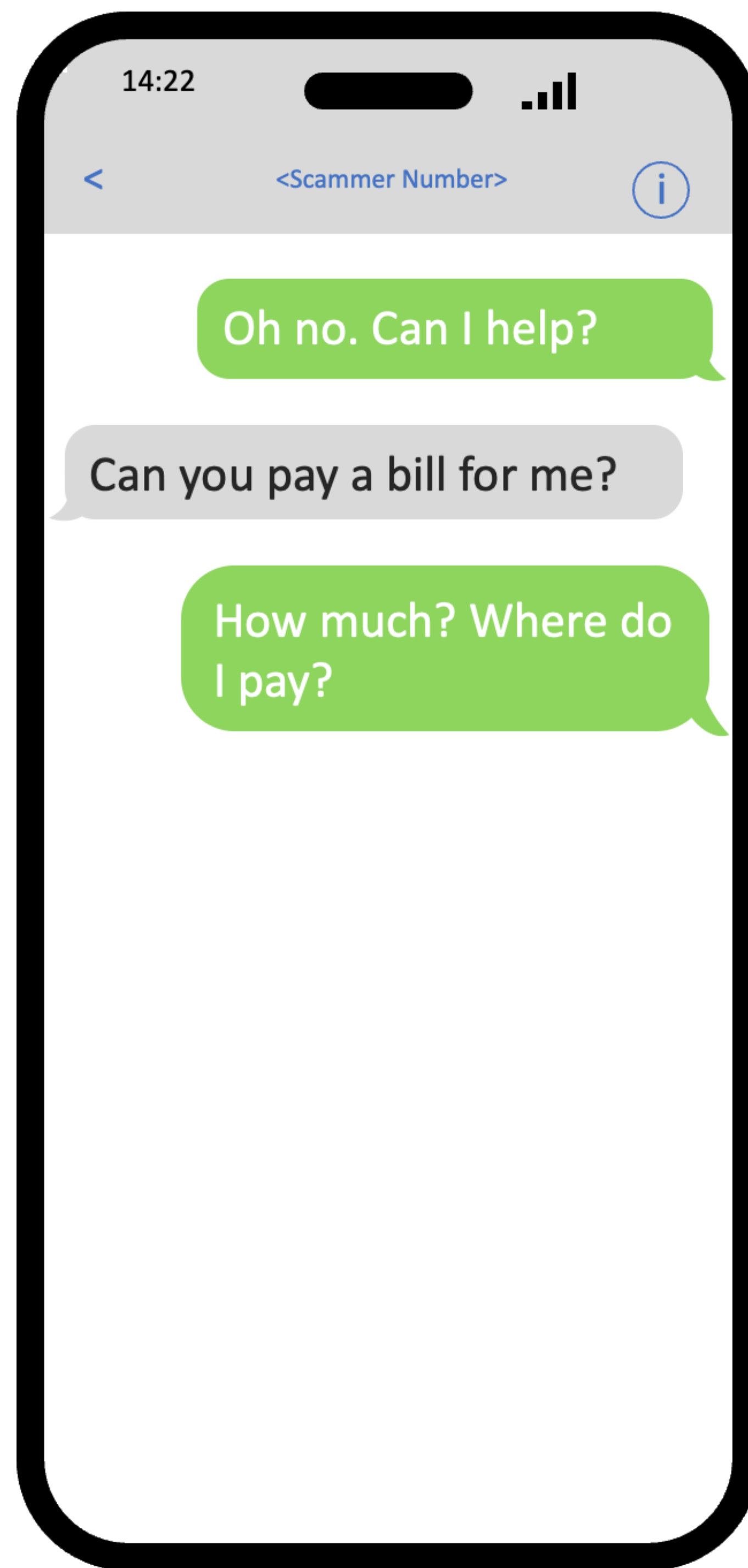
Scammer's first response

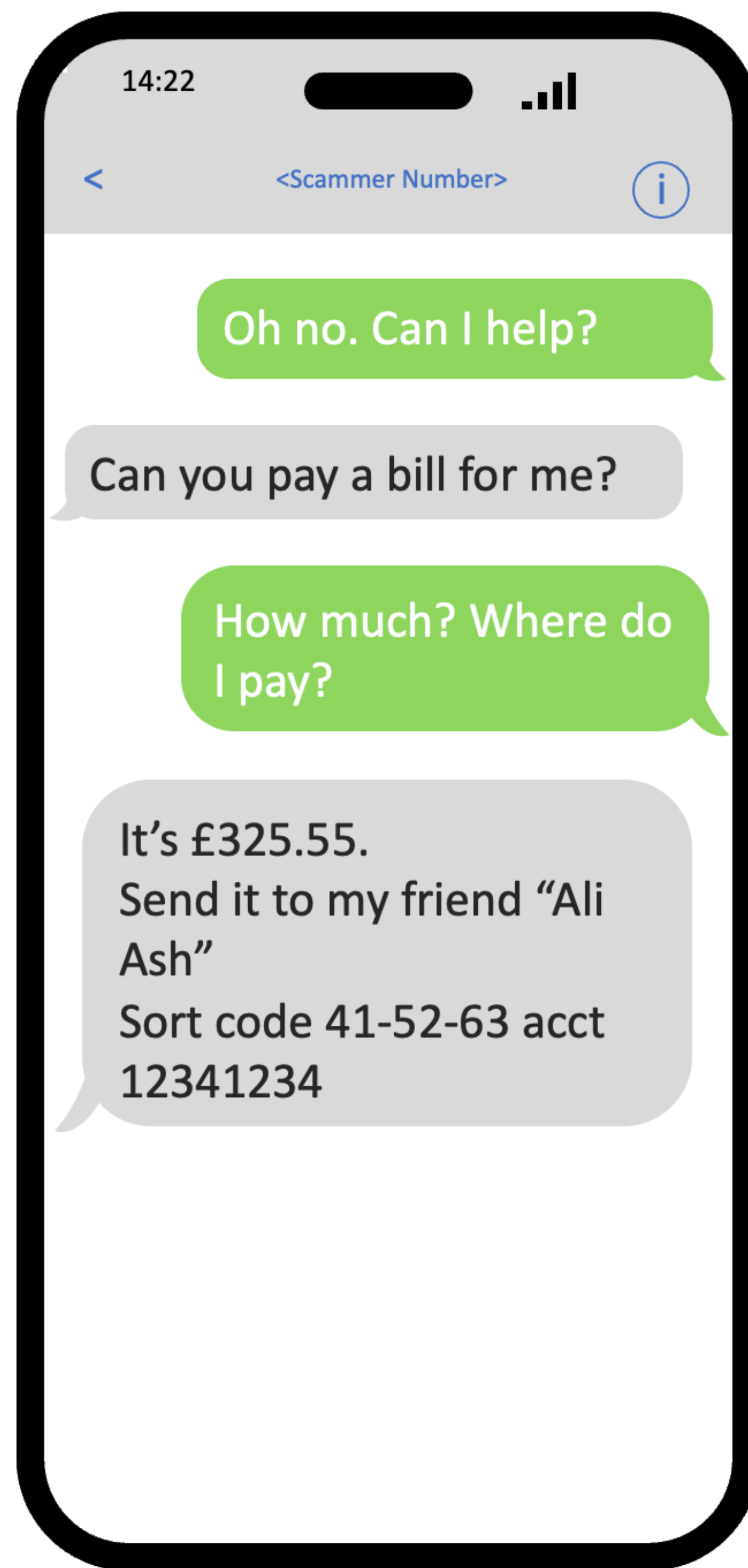




Scammer asks for help in
second response







Scammer provides **suspect**
mule account

Methodology

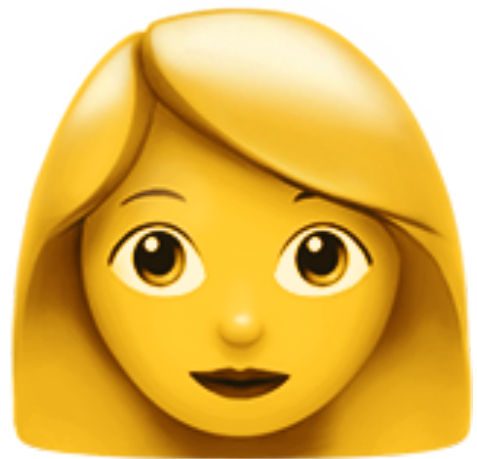
Collaborate with Stop Scams UK

Access 711 engaged conversations from 3,402 initial “Hi mum and dad” scam texts

Conduct textual 💬, financial 💰 and network analysis 🕸

Results: Scammer strategies

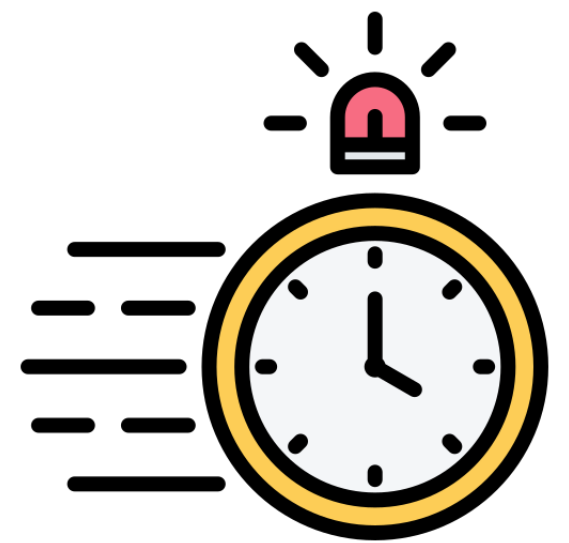
Scammers prefer to target
female users



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Scammers use the distraction, kindness,
and time/urgency lures to deceive users.



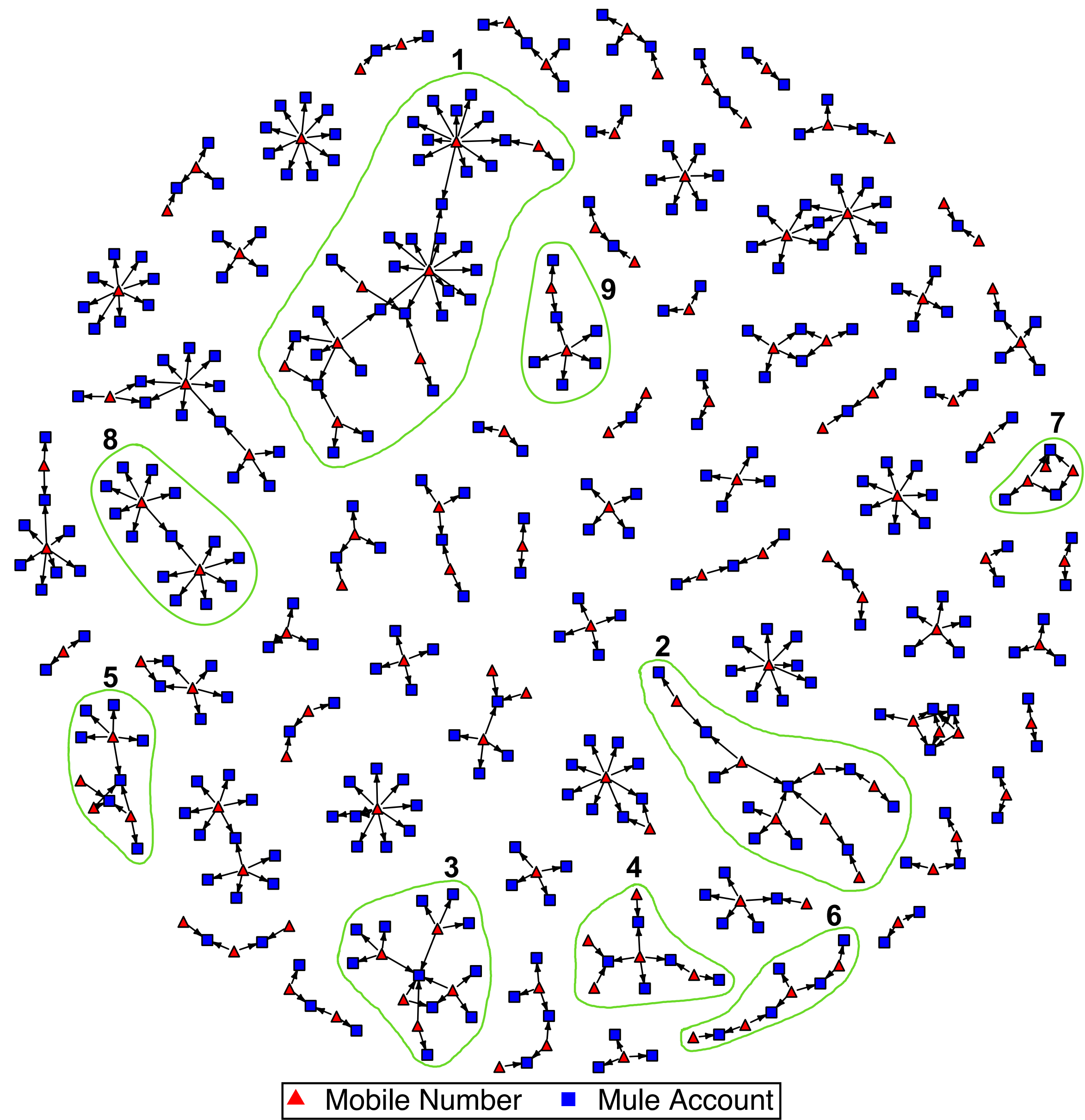
Results: Suspect mules

- Over £577k  requested from 270 unique scammer mobile numbers 
- 582 unique suspect mules  identified that belong to over 30 financial institutions 

Category	Financial institutions	Mule accounts (unique)
Electronic Money Institution	14	374
High Street	12	196
EEA Authorised (International)	2	6
Authorised Payment Institution	5	5
Small Electronic Money	1	1

Distribution of unique mule accounts ($n=582$) aggregated with their respective category of financial institutions ($n = 34$) as per the UK’s FCA handbook

Results: Scammer networks



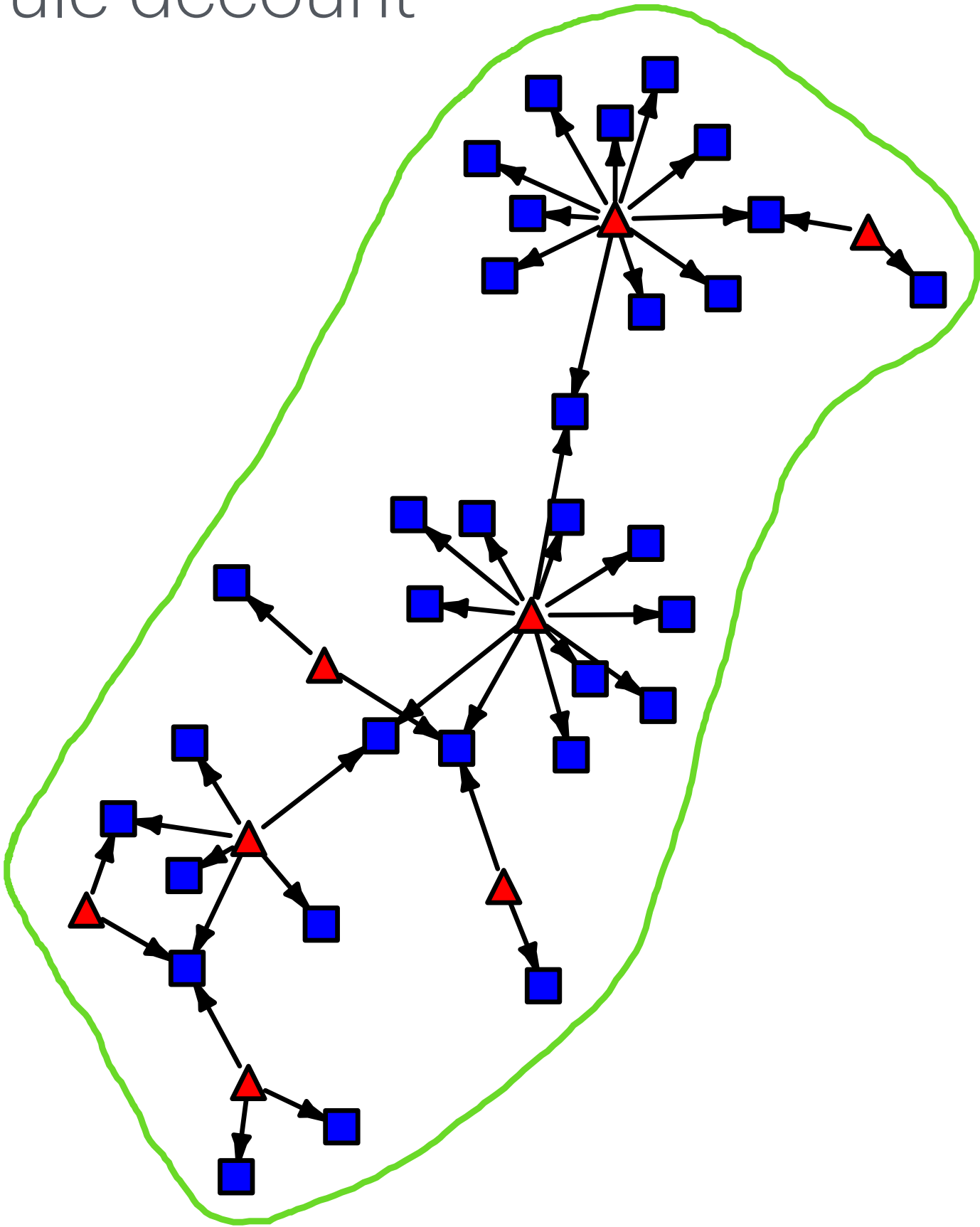
Group	Scammer mobile phone number	Mule accounts	Financial institutions	Amount requested (£)
1	8	31	8	41,125
2	7	10	7	14,487
3	5	11	4	9,452
4	5	5	5	11,400
5	4	7	6	14,231
6	4	5	4	11,728
7	3	3	3	18,000
8	2	13	7	10,700
9	2	6	6	10,965

Breakdown of amounts requested (round-off to nearest decimal) by the nine communities identified.

Results: Scammer networks

▲ Scammer mobile number

■ Mule account



Scammer Phone Numbers	Suspect Mule Accounts	Financial Institutions	Amount Requested
8	31	8	£41,125

Key Takeaways

- Users in the UK lose at least £2.3m (\$2.9m) per year to 'Hi mum and dad' scams. This is a growing concern around the world including the US.
- Scammers prefer mobile network operators that support GSM SIM boxes/banks/farms.
- Scammers continuously try to identify the amounts that could evade detection from financial institutions.
- Network analysis on suspect mules and mobile numbers indicate possible clusters (threat actor groups).

Read our paper:



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<https://sharad1126.github.io>

Thanks! See you at our poster